



DECISIVE MOMENT September 3, 1260

Battle of 'Ayn Jalut

United by Genghis Khan in 1206, the Mongols formed a group of tribes that embarked on a series of raids across Asia. By 1260, they had conquered an area stretching from the Pacific Ocean to the Mediterranean Sea, and were considered invincible. On September 3, 1260, the Mongols reached 'Ayn Jalut in Palestine, where they were met by the Mamluk Sultans.

The children and grandchildren of the Mongol leader Genghis Khan (see pp.164–65) took control of the Mongol tribes on his death in 1227. One of these grandchildren, Hülegü Khan, was given power over part of the Mongol army. He took this army into northwest Persia in 1255, raiding and looting as he went. In 1258 he defeated the Abbasid Caliphate (see pp.174–77), capturing and destroying the city of Baghdad and massacring the inhabitants. The Mongols now controlled Iraq and Persia. From here the Mongols pushed westward toward the Mediterranean. They overran Palestine and Syria, capturing the main city, Damascus, in 1259.

With Palestine and Syria conquered, Hülegü turned his attention to Egypt, the next major power to the west. He sent a message to its rulers, the Mamluks, asking them to surrender without a fight. Originally slaves taken from Turkish tribes and formed into an army by the previous rulers of Egypt, the Mamluks had overthrown the old government and taken power for themselves. Their new government was based on military principles, making it ideally suited for

waging war and unlikely to give in to threats. The Mamluk response was to kill Hülegü's envoys and march toward the Mongol army in Palestine.

At the same time, Hülegü was informed that his brother, the Mongol Emperor (or "Great Khan"), was dying. With ambitions to gain control of the Mongol Empire for himself, Hülegü took most of the army with him and headed back to his brother.

Meanwhile, the Mamluks entered Palestine with an army equal in size to the Mongol force Hülegü had left behind. At 'Ayn Jalut—also known as Goliath's Spring—they defeated the Mongols, using their heavy cavalry to great effect. The Mamluks took control of Syria and Palestine, expelling the remaining Crusaders (see pp.200–01) in 1291.

The Mongols had never been so emphatically defeated before, and this halted their conquests to the west. The internal fighting that followed split the Mongol tribes into different sections. In Iraq and Persia, they became the Ilkhanid dynasty and gradually took on the customs, religion, and language of the people they had conquered.

Mongol soldiers

This 13th-century Persian picture depicts Mongol soldiers in battle. The Mongol Empire was founded by Genghis Khan in 1206 and was one of the largest empires in history with an estimated population of 100 million people. At its height, it included territories from East Asia to central Europe.

“It is for you to fly and for us to pursue... Fortresses will not detain us.”

MESSAGE FROM HÜLEGÜ TO THE MAMLUKS DEMANDING THEIR SURRENDER, 1260